

SOUTH ASIA: SECURING THE FUTURE

“We will finish the Maoists in two to three years”

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South Asia today is perhaps the most difficult place in the world. It is the epicentre of terrorism. It's also the epicentre of Maoism. Being the largest country in South Asia—largest in terms of size, population, as well as the size of the economy—all countries in South Asia look to India either as a friend or as foe. Seen from a strategic point of view, India holds the key to political and economic stability in South Asia, and our responsibility is great because of our democratic and secular credentials are underpinned by the steady progress in the socio-economic sectors. India is seen as a friend by countries which take the same path of democracy, secularism, pluralism and inclusive growth. India is also seen as a threat by some countries. It, therefore, falls upon India to disprove the tag of a threat to any neighbour and send a message that it is ready to become the engine of change and the leader of economic development in the region.

The most serious threat to India arises from jihadi terrorism. It's unfortunate that the 21st century has seen a throwback of these crusaders. It appears that the world is getting divided into Islamic nations and non-Islamic nations. That is sad. It also presents a very grim future for countries which have people professing the Islamic faith, as well as a very large number of people professing other faiths. The best example is India. Any conflict between Islam and other religions had its greatest and most deleterious impact on countries like India. We are victims of jihadi terrorism. The epicentre of jihadi terrorism is Afghanistan and Pakistan. These elements are in other countries such as Bangladesh and Sri Lanka and now even in the Maldives. While we are obliged to take steps to strengthen our security system—we are doing that and will continue to do that—it is important that people belonging to all faiths in India learn to live in peace and harmony. Jihadi terrorism may not exactly be the flip side of communal violence, but communal violence and communal disharmony creates an environment where jihadi terrorism can flourish.

Having said that, let me say that just because we find the way in which people can live in peace and harmony does not mean that terrorism will come to an end. The jihadi terror-

ists have set before themselves enemies all over the world—Israel, the United States, Russia, Europe and even China. South Asia, therefore, has a duty to work together to put an end to jihadi terrorism. Bangladesh, until sometime ago, emerged as a major hub of terrorist groups targeting India. It became a transit point for terrorists. Likewise, Nepal became another transit point. Recently, there have been attempts to find safe havens in Maldives and Sri Lanka. It's, therefore, very important to work closely with our neighbours. I am happy that after Sheikh Hasina's Government took over, we have received splendid cooperation from Bangladesh. We have received splendid cooperation from Bhutan and Sri Lanka. We still have to find a way to Nepal and Myanmar, but I'm sure, over a period of time, our efforts on these countries will also succeed. As far as Nepal is concerned, recent developments are a matter of grave concern. A long period of political instability in this neighbouring country is taking its toll on economic issues. It has led to sprouting of anti-India activities, challenging the security of the Siliguri corridor in north Bengal besides providing sanctuary to those desirous to fomenting problems in the eastern part of India. Myanmar is in the process of yet another experiment with military-dictated parliamentary democracy. I do not wish to comment on whether that model will succeed or not. Myanmar is home to Indian insurgent groups which it tolerates as a state policy assuming that these groups will act as an insurance against perceived Indian inimical designs. We must evolve a policy required to meet the emerging challenges in Myanmar.

China, although not quite a part of South Asia, is clearly in the driver's seat as far as Asia is concerned. China has made no secrets of its ambitions to become the dominant player in South Asia. It is in the driver's seat in our immediate neighbourhood, especially for the countries mentioned above. It has a distinct advantage because it has forged its foreign policy in this region to secure its trade and security interests.

Turning to the next issue of Naxals and Maoism, it's a graver problem than jihadi terrorism. Jihadi terrorism can be countered successfully if you are able to share intelligence and act in real time. That is why 2009 was a year free of ter-